‘forecast’ – it could not have been made sooner than 1583, when Fathullah arrived in Akbar’s court – reinforces the idea of the predetermined perfection of the emperor’s rule. And if, again, Akbar had been content with such flattering portraits alone, his life might have provided little more than a study of pre-modern propaganda. In fact, Fathullah is not remembered for his horoscope as much as for overhauling the empire’s revenue and administration.

In 1585, together with Akbar’s brother-in-law, Bhagwant Das, Fathullah Shirazi proposed twenty reforms, mostly for the assessment of agricultural land and the welfare of its farmers and soldiers. Among these: tax collectors were to give receipts and credit any excess payment to the next year; the collectors’ own pay was to be reviewed and their expenses to be granted; soldiers were not to lose their pay if their horses died – the mansabdari salary being paid according to how many horses a man could bring to battle – instead, the salary was to be transferred to the new horse even if there was delay in branding it.

It is no wonder, then, that Badauni reports how every evening, ‘a most terrible crowd’ of needy Hindus and Muslims, men and women, healthy and sick, gathered below Akbar’s balcony, waiting for their lord, their benefactor, their God to appear. And every evening, when Akbar appeared, ‘the whole crowd prostrated themselves’. There was even a cult that grew around this ritual viewing – this darshan – of the emperor. Darshaniyas would come to ‘feast their eyes’[43] on Akbar when he made his first public appearance every morning.

A few years previously, Badauni notes how ‘low and mean fellows’ had hailed Akbar as the *sahib-i-zaman*, lord of the world, who ‘would remove all differences of opinion among the seventy-two sects of Islam and the Hindus’. Maulanas had dropped broad hints about ‘the promised appearance of the Mahdi’. Now it was ‘[c]heating, thieving Brahmans’, writes a disgusted Badauni, who ‘told the Emperor that he was an incarnation, like Ram, Krishna, and other infidel kings’, brought into the world to fulfil a prediction by which ‘a great conqueror would rise up in India, who would honour Brahmans and cows, and govern the earth with justice’.[44] This story has survived the ages, though in somewhat more vengeful form. The historian A.L. Srivastava remembers his father telling it